Notable

User guide and technical reference

Version 2.4.1

Contents

Set up and open the source app 2

Find your way around 4

Sort new documents through Inbox 5

Use Library, Notes, and notebooks 7

Bring an existing PC and tablet library together 10

Set up optional reMarkable PDF syncing 13

Understand originals, app copies, and storage 15

Troubleshooting 17

Reference and development 19

This PDF includes the complete README. The contents and web links are clickable. Setup, everyday use, existing-library cleanup, troubleshooting, and technical details are all included.

Notable

Notable helps you organize research documents and collect your PDF annotations into searchable notes and Word notebooks. You can use it entirely on your PC. Document identification through online services and connection to a reMarkable tablet are optional.

There are two related workflows:

- **Sorting documents:** review a suggested name and choose where an incoming PDF, Word document, or PowerPoint presentation belongs.
- **Reading PDF notes:** collect highlights, comments, drawings, and handwriting from watched PDF folders, then read, search, or export those notes.

Sorting supports `.pdf`, `.docx`, `.pptx`, and legacy `.ppt`. **Only PDFs enter note extraction, combined paper notes, Word notebooks, and reMarkable paper transfers.** Filing a Word or PowerPoint document does not turn it into a PDF or add it to the Notes tab.

This README starts with setup and ordinary use. The existing-library cleanup walkthrough explains how to work through disorganized collections a few papers at a time. Troubleshooting and technical reference follow afterward.

The current source version is **Notable 2.4.1**. This update brings PC and reMarkable notes together in one reading view and keeps margin handwriting visible. New syncs keep one main PDF in the paper folder and save tablet notes separately. Existing extra reading copies stay in place until you review their removal. An older saved library may also need a one-time note refresh; source PDFs are read, without changing their contents.

Set up and open the source app

First setup on Windows

This version runs from Python source. **No updated executable has been packaged. The executable in `dist/` belongs to the old version.** Use the source launcher when checking current behavior.

The project environment is configured for Python 3.13. Install Python 3.13, open PowerShell in the project folder, and run:

```
py -3.13 -m venv .venv
.\.venv\Scripts\python.exe -m pip install -r requirements.txt
.\.venv\Scripts\python.exe "PDF Note Organizer.py"
```

The first command creates the project's own Python environment. The second installs the packages into that environment. Creating `.venv` is a first-time step; reinstalling requirements is useful when dependencies change.

For later launches, run this from the project folder:

```
& ".\Run PDF Note Organizer.ps1"
```

This script chooses the project's Python explicitly. It uses the same saved project library as a direct source launch, then restores the shell's previous environment settings when the app exits.

Open it in VS Code

Open the project folder in VS Code and install its Python extension. In **Run and Debug**, select **Notable - development library**, then press **F5**. That profile explicitly uses `.venv/Scripts/python.exe` and the project's `.local-data` directory.

Two other profiles are available:

- **Notable - synthetic example** opens a disposable example with highlights, handwriting, and an arrow.
- **Notable - regression tests** runs the automated test suite. Tests are also available through VS Code's Testing panel.

Activating `.venv` in a terminal does not change the Python selected by VS Code's current-file debugger. If an error says `No module named 'docx'`, use the named development profile or the PowerShell launcher above. If it still fails, install `requirements.txt` using `.venv`'s Python.

Know which saved library you opened

Your **paper folders** and the app's **saved data directory** serve different purposes. A paper folder contains your actual research files. The data directory contains Notable's database, settings, history, and retained tablet sources.

Direct source launches and the PowerShell launcher normally use `.local-data/` beside the source entry point. This location does not depend on the shell's current folder. The development F5 profile explicitly selects `.local-data` and skips importing old watched folders.

An explicitly set `PDF_NOTES_DATA_DIR` overrides the source app and launcher's default. An older packaged app normally uses `%LOCALAPPDATA%/PDF Note Organizer/`; it may therefore show a different saved library from the source version.

Open **Settings** → **Library & diagnostics** to see the active location in a compact path box. Hover over it to see the whole path and an explanation of what it contains. The small copy button beside it copies the complete location. **Open data folder** opens it in File Explorer. The library summaries underneath can be scrolled and copied too.

File and folder paths use the same controls throughout the app: hover over the path to see its complete current value together with the explanation, and use the small copy button beside it to copy the full location. The button's tooltip says **Copy full path** and identifies the location it will copy. These actions do not change the folder or save draft settings. A blank or unselected location has its copy button disabled.

Some details panels contain several locations, such as an original file and its destination. Choose the location in the panel's small list, then use its copy button. **Copy details** copies the entire explanation and its paths together. You can reach the path copy buttons with Tab and activate them with Space or Enter. There is no separate right-click menu for paths.

In Notes, the folder copy button copies the selected watched folder. The paper copy button copies the chosen paper's location. When viewing **All papers**, it copies the selected note's source PDF; its tooltip identifies that source. In the expanded processing log, **Locations** lets you choose a recorded file, recovery copy, or watched folder to copy.

Read-only summaries may identify other project or installed libraries. Selecting a different data directory on launch loads that library's own watched folders, settings, and credentials. Diagnostics does not merge or move libraries.

One app instance can use a given data directory at a time. Original applications remain available for rollback. Close the old Paper Sorter before enabling Notable's automatic Inbox checks so both apps do not try to handle the same incoming file.

Find your way around

The window title is **Notable**. **Settings** and **Help** sit at the right of the tab row.

Place	Use it for	What the main action changes
Inbox	Review incoming document names and destinations.	**File document** puts the selected file in its chosen library folder and removes the Inbox copy after successful filing.
Library	Choose watched PDF folders, inspect their papers, and manage processing.	**Add folder** registers an existing folder for PDF notes. It does not move its papers.
Notes	Read and search extracted annotations; open papers and export notes.	Read saved notes, export Word documents, or save an annotated PDF.
reMarkable	Connect, download tablet PDF annotations, map folders, and review outgoing transfers.	Cloud actions use the connection and the separately enabled transfer permissions.
Settings	Choose naming permissions, PDF viewing, processing defaults, and optional connections.	**Save preferences** commits the draft; **Cancel** discards it.

For a new library, reMarkable cloud services start **off**, and its tab is hidden. Enable them through **Settings** → **Connections** and save to reveal the tab. Turning the master switch off hides the tab and pauses cloud activity while keeping downloaded notes, pairing, and folder links. Existing configured libraries retain their saved connection choices.

An empty library normally opens on Inbox. A library with saved notes normally opens on Notes. **Open folder** in Library opens the selected watched folder in File Explorer. In Notes it opens the selected folder; select a specific folder first if you are viewing all folders.

The footer describes background work. **View sync details** appears when a check or recovery needs attention and takes you to Library's processing log. In Library, **Show sync details** expands that log and **Hide sync details** collapses it. Unavailable watched folders, PDF read failures, pending notebook exports, and retained previous PDF copies are reported separately. The log includes complete saved recovery paths so you can find those copies in File Explorer.

Read long paths and explanations

Hover over a button for a short explanation. Path fields and path entries in tables show the complete location together with their explanation, even when the displayed filename fits. Other clipped table cells reveal their complete text. Long tooltips can widen to fit the available monitor space; moving away, switching tabs, or changing focus dismisses them.

Long filenames in Inbox also show their full current text on hover. Inbox metadata, Help, and annotation history have scrollbars so longer information stays readable. **Escape** follows the same action as a dialog's Cancel or Close button. In Settings, this discards draft changes, including a pending key removal; a save already in progress must finish first.

Drag the divider between column headings to resize a column. **Double-click that divider** to fit the column to its current rows. A manually sized column keeps its size through refreshes. Horizontal scrollbars appear when needed; **Shift + mouse wheel** pans across a wide table. Dividers between the Notes list and preview can also be dragged.

Sort new documents through Inbox

Choose the two folders

Open **Settings** → **Sorting** and choose:

- An **incoming folder**, such as `C:\Incoming`, for downloads that still need review.
- A **library root**, such as `C:\Literature`, beneath which you will file finished documents.

These must be different folders. Neither can contain the other, and neither can be inside the app's private data, cache, or reMarkable review areas. When automatic checking is enabled, both folders must already exist.

You can instead use **Import sorter settings...** to load an old Paper Sorter JSON file into the Settings draft. Import brings in folders and naming choices. It does not import a Gemini key, enable Gemini, or start automatic checking. Inspect the draft, then choose **Save preferences**.

Automatic Inbox checks run while Notable is open. You can leave them off and use **Refresh inbox** whenever you want to review downloads. Scanning checks file readiness; it does not identify papers online, move files, or upload them.

File one document

1. Put a supported document directly in the incoming folder, or use **Add documents...**. Dragging supported files onto the Inbox list also copies them into that folder. The externally selected source stays where it was.
2. Choose **Refresh inbox** if necessary. A file must finish downloading and stop changing before it becomes ready. Subfolders of the incoming folder are not scanned as new downloads. Office lock files and unsupported file types are ignored.
3. Select a ready document and choose **Review selected**. Notable reads its available text and metadata using your naming permissions, then suggests a filename.
4. Check the proposed title, authors, year, and any review explanation. Edit the filename if needed. Enter only the filename; the source extension is retained and added if omitted.

5. Choose an existing destination below the library root, or type a new subfolder path. A new destination folder is created only when you confirm filing.
6. Choose **File document**, check the name and destination in the confirmation, and confirm.

Filing saves a complete copy without overwriting an existing destination file. It keeps a recovery journal - a saved record of the source, destination, and copy progress - before removing the incoming source. If the source changes during review or filing, it must be reviewed again. A name collision leaves the incoming file and existing destination intact so you can choose another name.

Before removing the incoming file, the app verifies both copies and protects them from simultaneous edits or replacement. If a file changes or cannot be protected, the available copies stay in place for review. Adding a file that changes during copying can also leave a copy in Inbox; inspect it before retrying.

A confirmed PDF is handed to the local note library. DOCX, PPTX, and PPT remain locally filed documents and do not enter the PDF note pipeline. The sorting root can cover a broad collection while the optional tablet link covers only one selected portion of it.

Skip sets a document aside without moving it. You can review it again later; changed contents return it to the incoming queue. If identification fails, the document may still be named manually. **Retry lookup** retries identification and retains a filename you edited.

After an interruption, Notable recovers journaled copies before handing pending PDFs to the library. Uncertain copies remain for review, with their source and destination explained. Read the recovery issue before retrying a filename that may already exist at its destination.

Open **Inbox** → **Filing recovery…** to see retained filing issues. Select a row, read both complete paths, and use **Open inbox** and **Open containing folder** to inspect the available copies. This dialog does not automatically choose, move, or delete a copy.

Choose how names are identified

Local only reads text and built-in metadata on your computer and makes no naming-service requests.

Smart can use two separately permitted services:

- A DOI lookup sends an exact DOI found in the document to Crossref or DataCite for citation details. A DOI is a permanent publication identifier. This lookup sends the identifier rather than the document text or file. The app checks that the returned title and other details fit the document.
- Optional Gemini identification can send extracted document text as a backup when citation information is incomplete. It requires **Use Gemini for document identification** and your own key. Word and PowerPoint also require their separate text-sharing permissions.

Gemini starts off. Each user supplies their own key, protected for their Windows account in that saved library. Ordinary sorter import does not bring in a key. A blank key field normally keeps an existing saved key.

Remove saved key is a draft action. It disables Gemini in the draft and changes the button to **Undo removal**. The key is still saved until **Save preferences** succeeds. **Undo removal**, **Cancel**, or closing Settings before saving preserves it. A successful save removes this library's key and turns Gemini off. Separate key files and the old sorter's settings are not changed.

All Settings tabs save together. If saving fails, the dialog stays open, the previous saved preferences and key remain, and you can correct or cancel the draft. If automatic Inbox checks cannot restart after a successful save, the app reports that separately: the preferences have been saved, and a manual refresh is still available.

DOCX and PPTX text each require their own Gemini permission. Legacy PPT files need local/manual review and are not sent to Gemini. Filename formats and a limited custom template let you choose a naming pattern; a custom template contains supported tokens, not a path or extension.

Use Library, Notes, and notebooks

Watch an existing PDF folder

Choose **Library** → **Add folder** and select an existing folder of PDFs. Notable reads annotated PDFs recursively and saves their notes. It reads source PDFs without editing them.

Each watched folder is an independent project with its own processing settings and generated notebook. Overlapping watched folders are supported, but can present the same files in more than one project. Start with non-overlapping folders if you do not need that arrangement.

Changes are watched while the app is open. Startup and periodic reconciliation scans catch changes made while it was closed. **Library** → **Sync PDFs** checks local folders on demand. The button in the reMarkable tab performs a separate cloud check.

Select a paper and choose **View notes**, or double-click its row, to open its notes. **Open PDF** prepares one reading PDF with the paper's PC and reMarkable notes together. This happens in the background. Notable first checks that the printed pages and their positions match. Different editions, added or reordered tablet pages, and several independently annotated copies need review before they can be combined. Saved notes and their separate histories remain intact.

To keep or share that reading PDF, choose **More** → **Export annotated PDF…** in Library or Notes. Choose a separate destination. This is a lasting export with the combined annotations; the temporary reading view is not intended as your working original. Continue making PC annotations in your main original and tablet annotations on your tablet, then sync to refresh the combined view.

Handwriting can extend beyond an article's original page edge. **Open PDF** and **Export annotated PDF** add white space around supported margin notes so the whole note stays visible, including handwriting already saved in a PC PDF or an older tablet reading copy. The article stays at its original size, and its text stays searchable. Only the generated reading or export PDF gets the extra space; your original file keeps its existing page size. A wider page can make the article look smaller when your viewer uses **Fit page** or **Fit width**; zoom in for a larger reading size. These reading PDFs use the same temporary cache as combined notes and can be rebuilt when needed.

The combined view belongs to Notable. Your tablet keeps its own editable document and tablet notes. PC annotations appear together with those notes in Notable and its PDF export; this update does not add them to the existing document on the tablet. Sending an exported combined PDF back would create another imported copy, so it is not part of the normal workflow.

The generated Word notebook collects linked PC and tablet notes under one paper. After a paper has been verified and refreshed for this version, its PDF links open the main original at the verified page, so those links do not depend on a temporary reading view. The original may not show newer tablet marks. Older tablet copies keep links

to their retained reading PDFs until that refresh succeeds. Use **Open PDF** in Notable, or **Export annotated PDF…**, when you want to see all marks on the page.

Read and search notes

Choose a folder and paper in Notes. **All folders** searches the saved library across watched folders. Search and the available filters can narrow highlighted text, comments, handwriting transcription, publication metadata, annotation color, and note type.

Highlights and typed comments use text and source-page links. Drawings and handwriting also have retained context images. **More** offers an editable notebook copy and annotation history for the selected note's actual source. The preview's **Details** checkbox reveals extraction information when you need it.

Feedback beside a tab's controls describes your last action there and clears when you leave the tab. The footer continues to show background work.

Understand the page number

PDF page 3 of 12 means the physical, one-based position inside the PDF. That is the page sent to the viewer. An embedded label can appear separately as **PDF label 233**. A verified printed journal number appears as **Journal p. 233**; an embedded PDF label alone does not prove the journal numbering. Automatic verification of journal page numbering is not implemented.

Change the viewer in **Settings** → **Preferences**. New libraries use **Windows default**. Explicit choices include Edge, Chrome, Firefox, Acrobat/Reader, SumatraPDF, and **Other application** for a chosen `.exe`. Saving this choice does not change Windows file associations.

Recognized viewers receive the physical page position. An unrecognized default or custom viewer can open the PDF normally, with an explanation of the page to navigate to. A missing explicitly selected viewer produces an error and directions to change the preference. Page jumps depend on the viewer honoring its parameter; every viewer has not been checked live.

Inspect handwriting and drawing context

The usual drawing preview is a saved close-up of the source page containing its text, figures, and marks. Nearby letters and strokes are grouped into blocks, with surrounding context. **Open PDF** and **Full page context** use the combined reading view. Supported margin handwriting can expand that view's page boundaries without changing your original PDF.

Enlarge image opens the saved close-up. **Full page context** opens the complete physical PDF page, including supported margin context. In either image window:

- **Fit width** or **Fit height** follows window resizing.
- **Ctrl + mouse wheel** zooms around the pointer and chooses manual zoom.
- **Double-click** restores Fit width.
- Scroll vertically, drag to pan, or use **Shift + mouse wheel** horizontally.

Select the watched folder in Library and open **Folder settings** to adjust grouping:

Setting	When it helps
Nearby blocks	The default; combines nearby letters and lines into readable notes.
Nearby lines	Uses less vertical joining when separate notes are being combined.
Whole page	Keeps all drawing marks on a page together, useful for diagrams or arrows joining distant items.
Joining distance	Increase it for a split phrase; decrease it when independent notes merge.
Context margin	Increase it to show more surrounding material.

PDFs usually do not identify which separate pen strokes belong to one thought, so automatic grouping makes an informed estimate. Manual crop adjustment, merge/split controls, and per-page overrides are future work.

Optional OCR is off by default and requires Tesseract on `PATH`. It works on isolated ink to reduce confusion with printed text. Its transcription is labeled a suggestion. Visual context remains available without OCR, and handwriting recognition is not guaranteed.

Work with generated Word notebooks

Open notebook opens `Notes on <folder>.generated.docx`. The default **Reading** layout groups selected passages under paper and page headings, with comments shown as **Note:**. **Detailed**, selected in Folder settings, includes more extraction information.

The notebook collects your annotations; it does not write a research synthesis for you. Notes follow the PDF's internal text order, which can still be incorrect in some two-column PDFs.

Use these actions for different purposes:

Action	Result
Open notebook	Opens the folder's generated Word document.
Save editable copy	Creates a separate document for your own writing. The app does not regenerate that copy.
Export view	Writes a separate Word notebook for the currently filtered notes.
Rebuild notebook…	Regenerates the folder's notebook from saved annotations using current formatting. It does not re-read PDFs.

Rebuild notebook… is in the watched-folder context menu. Its confirmation names the target and explains replacement. Run **Sync PDFs** first if the saved notes or screenshots need refreshing; formatting-only changes can reuse saved notes.

You can open the watched-folder context menu with a right-click, **Shift + F10**, or the keyboard Menu key. **Remove folder...** asks for confirmation and removes that project's saved library and history; PDFs and Word notebooks stay on disk.

If you edit a generated notebook directly, the next replacement preserves the edited document in the adjacent **Notebook backups** folder. Those edits are not merged into the new generated document. An editable copy is the clearer place for ongoing research writing. Old v1 notebooks are not selected as the new generated export target.

If the notebook changes while the app is saving, the app keeps that changed file and holds the export for another attempt. An interruption can also leave a complete previous copy beside it, named like `notes.docx.<identifier>.preserved`. Sometimes the new notebook has saved successfully and only removal of the previous copy failed. The log reports the retained copy's full location. Compare the available documents before deciding which to keep; changes made immediately after a successful save are still treated as your edits on the next update.

If Word locks a generated document, the export stays pending and retries periodically, normally every 30 seconds. Extracted notes remain in the database. Source links depend on the PDF viewer and Word honoring local file/page links; the physical page number is still written in the notebook.

Bring an existing PC and tablet library together

You do not need to organize every folder before starting. Work on a small, understandable part of your collection, check the result, then move to the next part. Duplicate review combines the app's presentation of a paper; it does not delete disk copies or clean out the tablet automatically.

1. Choose one starting area

1. Identify one PC folder containing a few papers you recognize. Leave the remaining folders where they are for now.
2. Make a backup of your research files and Notable's data directory with Notable closed. The data directory does not replace a backup of your original paper folders.
3. Launch the source app and check **Settings** → **Library & diagnostics** so you know which saved library you are updating.
4. Keep automatic PDF sending and folder creation off while you learn the cleanup workflow. Confirm the saved switches if this is an already configured library.
5. Add the existing PC folder through **Library** → **Add folder**. Do not put the whole existing collection into Inbox merely to make it searchable. Inbox is for documents you intend to file.
6. Let the local scan finish, inspect a few notes, and open the generated notebook. This gives you a local starting point before adding tablet copies.

2. Load the tablet information you want to compare

If you are only organizing PC files, skip this step. **Review library...** can compare local PDFs without a cloud connection.

For tablet comparison, enable reMarkable in Connections, pair it, and choose the limited cloud source and PC destination described in the next section. **Refresh folders** loads the folder catalog; **Sync PDFs** downloads

supported PDF sources and annotations. Keep outgoing transfers off until you decide which existing papers should be sent.

Review uses locally saved tablet information. A folder refresh is not the same as downloading each starting PDF and its tablet annotations. That starting PDF is called a **baseline**: the imported document before additional tablet marks are applied. An unmatched item in the saved tablet information does not prove that a paper is absent from the tablet. Recheck after a useful sync when the available information is incomplete.

3. Review a few findings

1. Open **Review library...** from Inbox or Library.
2. Choose the PC folder to inspect and choose **Check library**. This scan uses local PDFs and saved tablet information; it does not download, upload, delete, move, or link papers.
3. Use the box marked **Search**, beside the magnifying glass, and the finding filter to work on one topic or type of finding. Search checks names, explanations, and file locations. Click a column heading to sort the rows.
4. Select one finding. Read its complete explanation, local paths, and tablet IDs in the scrollable details area. Select text to copy it, or right-click and choose **Copy all text**. Choose the copy in the path selector, then use **Open PDF** and **Open containing folder** to inspect its contents and location before deciding. Hover over the path selector to read the whole location, or use its small copy button to copy it.
5. Decide whether this is the same paper, a different edition, supplementary material, or an independent item. DOI/title similarity is a suggestion to inspect, not a reason to merge automatically. A matching baseline is stronger evidence, but different annotations still need preservation.

Generated **Notebook backups** and **notes_media** folders, plus the hidden **.git** folder used for source code history, are left out of these findings. The app's private tablet cache and review areas are also excluded. These support folders are not ordinary paper folders to link to the tablet.

Then choose the action that fits:

Review action	What it means
Link selected copies...	Confirm that the selected sources belong to one paper. They share a paper entry and notebook heading; actual PDFs, source histories, and independent notes remain.
Keep separate	Record that this suggested match should stay separate. It does not delete either source or its notes.
Review again	Bring a previously kept-separate finding back into consideration when you want to reconsider it.
Undo last link...	Restore the paper memberships from the most recent supported link operation. It does not undo file moves or transfers, because linking did not perform those actions.
Map and sync...	Choose the corresponding existing PC folder beneath the linked root, then save that mapping and sync. Folder names may differ on PC and tablet.

Review action	What it means
Send selected PDF…	Explicitly review sending one existing local PDF to its linked tablet destination. Sending must be enabled in Connections.

Linking combines the paper's entry, rather than removing duplicate files. Two disk files can remain even though Notes shows one paper. A text annotation appears once only when the app can prove that the same mark was carried over from another saved source. Uncertain overlap and drawings remain preserved. Do not remove a physical PDF just because the app now presents one heading.

Undo is available for the latest new link recorded by this version. Legacy links cannot be undone through this action. If affected paper memberships have changed afterward, the app can refuse an unsafe undo rather than overwrite later work.

4. Resolve folder differences gradually

Select the tablet folder and choose its PC counterpart beneath the linked PC root. A tablet folder named `Catalysts` can map to a PC folder named `Catalysis`; you do not need to rename both libraries to match.

The selected-folder **Map and sync…** action saves the mapping and starts a sync. Read the selected source and destination before confirming, because a sync can download changed PDFs and process any separately enabled transfer/folder queues. This is different from **Apply folder changes** in Sync setup, which saves the main source and PC root.

Missing PC destinations appear as **Needs mapping**. If the folder you want is outside the linked PC root, stop and decide whether that root is correct rather than trying to link an unrelated folder. Optional folder mirroring is for new additions; it does not resolve every pre-existing mismatch for you.

5. Check the result before the next batch

For each small batch, use this checklist:

- [ ] I checked the explanation and opened the relevant PDFs.
- [ ] I linked only copies whose paper identity I understand, or chose Keep separate.
- [ ] I checked the PC and tablet folder destinations before mapping or sending.
- [ ] I ran the appropriate local or cloud sync and inspected any review/transfer issue.
- [ ] I opened Notes or the generated notebook and checked that independent annotations remain.
- [ ] I left uncertain papers and physical duplicates in place for later review.

A few checked papers are a useful stopping point. You can close the review window and continue another day; confirmed links and review decisions remain saved.

If a watched PC folder has moved

If you already moved a watched folder in File Explorer, find its old entry in Library, right-click it, and choose **Locate moved folder…**. Select the folder's existing new location and confirm.

This reconnects saved paths while keeping notes, annotation history, and folder settings together. It does not move or delete files. It is preferable to removing the old watched folder and adding a fresh one, because **Remove folder…** removes that project's saved library/history even though its disk files remain.

Choose the actual moved collection, not a similarly named replacement. A relocation can also affect linked roots and queued transfers. Transfers whose destination needs renewed confirmation remain for review; check their explanation before retrying. Use the normal folder mapping tools when you are linking a tablet folder, rather than relocating a watched folder that has not moved.

Set up optional reMarkable PDF syncing

The connection is direct between Notable and reMarkable's cloud. It does not require OneDrive integration, a USB cable, or developer mode. It handles imported PDFs and their tablet annotations; native notebooks and EPUBs are skipped.

Pair and choose a limited scope

1. Open **Settings** → **Connections**, enable cloud services, and choose **Save preferences**. The reMarkable tab becomes visible.
2. Choose **Connect reMarkable…**, open the pairing page, and sign in there. Generate the eight-character, single-use code and enter it in Notable. The app asks for that code, not your account password.
3. In **Sync setup**, choose the exact **Cloud source** and an existing **PC destination**. For example, tablet `Literature` can correspond directly to `C:\Literature`. Only that source and its descendants are in scope.
4. Choose **Apply folder changes** to save the source/root draft. Setup can collapse to a source-to-destination summary; **Edit setup** opens it again.
5. Choose **Sync PDFs** for an on-demand check. If root/source edits are pending, the button becomes **Apply & sync PDFs**, which saves them before checking.

The default source-name search looks for `Literature`. Choose the exact folder after connecting if that name is ambiguous. A blank source does not silently select the entire tablet library. Pairing credentials are protected for the current Windows account.

Automatic checks (every 5 min) controls PDF-download checks while the app is open. That checkbox applies immediately; it is separate from the source/root draft and from Settings' permission switches. Tablet marks appear after the tablet uploads them over Wi-Fi.

Know what each cloud action can do

Action or switch	Consequence
Refresh folders	Reads the cloud folder catalog without downloading PDFs. If folder mirroring is enabled, it can create PC counterparts or queue tablet folders.
Sync PDFs	Downloads changed supported PDFs/annotations, retries eligible review items, and processes enabled outgoing PDF/folder queues.
Send newly filed PDFs in linked folders	Allows newly filed PDFs within the linked PC root to enter the outgoing queue. Existing papers are not bulk uploaded merely by launching the app.
Send selected PDF…	Queues an explicitly chosen existing PDF, subject to sending permission and destination checks.
PC-to-tablet folder creation	Allows new PC folders beneath the linked root to receive tablet counterparts. Creating a folder does not upload all its existing papers.
Tablet-to-PC folder creation	Allows new tablet folders beneath the selected source to receive PC counterparts.
Master Connections switch off	Pauses cloud activity and hides the tab, retaining saved pairing, routes, PDFs, and notes.
Disconnect	Removes the active pairing; downloaded PDFs and notes remain. Reconnect needs a new pairing code.

Folder creation switches are independent. Their first check records the folders already present, so old unmatched folders still need review. New nested folders are handled parent-first. Invalid names, collisions, missing parents, and ambiguous routes remain for review. The creation workflow does not propagate ordinary user-folder renames, moves, or deletions across both libraries.

Matching descendant paths route downloads to existing PC folders. Explicit mappings override that path matching, and use stable tablet folder IDs. **Unlink folder…** asks for confirmation. Unlinking the main source clears its PC destination and disables automatic checks; choosing a destination again resumes routing. Unlinking a descendant's explicit override returns it to source-path matching. Existing PDFs and notes remain in both cases.

Handle downloads needing attention

Unmatched or unsupported conversions appear in **PDFs needing attention**. Their retained material is under `<library data directory>/reMarkable Review/<document ID>/`. Select an item to read its full reason, proposed destination, and retained PDF path. **Open PDF** opens a retained review PDF when one exists; **Copy details** copies the explanation and paths.

A folder mapping is usually the better way to direct future downloads. The app's private review/cache areas are excluded from note scanning, even if a watched parent contains them. If you manually copy a reviewed PDF into a

normal watched folder, it becomes an independently analyzed local source; that does not create a reliable route for future tablet updates.

Repeated unchanged conversion failures are held for review instead of being reconverted every five minutes. A manual sync, changed routing, a renderer update, or a resolved local conflict can permit another attempt.

Review outgoing transfers

Open **Transfer queue…** to see uploads and folder-creation work, including **Needs mapping**, review, retryable failures, completed transfers, and cancelled entries. Local filing completes independently of an offline cloud service.

Select a transfer to see its complete PC path, status, explanation, and any recorded destination paths in the details area. You can scroll and copy these details even after a transfer is sent or cancelled.

Retry transfers processes currently eligible work. **Retry selected…** asks you to confirm the chosen unfinished job's current file and linked destination. If the PDF changed after it was queued, this accepts its current contents. If the linked root/source or destination changed, it accepts the new destination. A changed PDF after an ambiguous earlier send can need a new additive transfer while retaining the earlier cloud item.

Cancel selected transfer cancels future work on the selected unfinished transfer. It does not delete the local file or folder, and it does not delete a cloud item that may already have been committed before cancellation. A completed transfer cannot be rolled back by queue cancellation.

Saved transfer IDs support retries after an uncertain cloud response. Confirmed links are reused when the app knows how the copies were related; uncertain matches remain for review. These protections are covered by offline tests, but the full workflow still needs a small real-device pilot before taking over an established watcher.

Understand originals, app copies, and storage

Several files can represent one paper for different reasons. A link in Notable records their relationship; it does not erase those files.

Stored material	Purpose and retention
Your original PC PDF	Your research file, possibly containing existing Acrobat/viewer annotations. Note extraction reads it without editing it.
Retained tablet baseline PDF	The unchanged imported PDF needed to reconstruct tablet annotations. Identical baselines share stored content using a digital fingerprint computed from the file's bytes. A baseline can still duplicate a user-owned PC original.
Tablet layers and source records	Tablet marks, page ordering, and reconstruction details kept separately from the baseline. Small records, called manifests in the code, identify the saved source files.
Temporary combined reading PDF	Created privately when you open a paper. It includes the verified PC and tablet annotations. It can be removed and rebuilt from the saved sources without losing notes. The normal budget is 128 MB.

Stored material	Purpose and retention
Exported annotated PDF	A lasting combined copy saved only when you choose Export annotated PDF. You choose its location and whether to replace a previous export.
Database notes and history	Extracted note text, drawing context, saved processing state, paper links, and annotation history in `library.sqlite3`.
Generated Word notebook	A replaceable export beside its watched folder. Use an editable copy for personal writing.
Notebook backups	Preserved externally edited generated notebooks before replacement.
Temporary cloud download cache	Downloaded pieces that can be fetched again, with a default 64 MB budget. Retained annotation sources are stored elsewhere.

New successful syncs do not put a `[reMarkable <ID>]` reading PDF beside every original. A verified existing main paper is reused. If a tablet paper has no PC counterpart, Notable saves its original PDF under its ordinary name. An occupied name or uncertain match goes to review. Your main original remains the place for PC annotations; Notable does not rewrite it with incoming tablet notes. Cloud renames or moves do not automatically move your originals, and cloud deletion keeps the saved sources and notes.

The 64 MB download cache and 128 MB reading cache are **not whole-library limits**. Originals, retained baselines, tablet layers, older sources, note history and explicit exports are kept separately. A retained baseline can still duplicate your editable PC original: this backup lets Notable reconstruct tablet notes even if the PC file is edited or goes missing. Identical tablet baselines share one private copy. This update removes the need for a permanent extra *annotated reading PDF* for each paper; it does not promise that all backup storage disappears.

Only unchanged, recognizable app-generated reading views are cleared from the temporary cache. A PDF you edited there is preserved. The currently requested PDF can exceed the budget on its own, and open files or files needing review can also keep the folder above its normal budget. This protects your work, but a temporary view should still be exported before you rely on it as a lasting document.

Review existing extra reading copies

After a successful sync and notebook refresh, open **Library → More → Review extra PDFs...**. This lists the old `[reMarkable <ID>]` copies and explains which ones are ready for removal. Nothing is removed merely by opening the list or upgrading the app.

A copy is ready only when its saved tablet source is verified, its notes and histories have moved to the new private records, its main original is available, and current generated Word notebooks no longer link to the old copy. Edited copies, unverified tablet revisions and unresolved links remain blocked. An older reading copy can be ready when its exact tablet marks are still saved and came from the same imported original PDF. Read each explanation; you can work through a few papers at a time.

Select ready copies, read the warning about old links, and choose **Remove reviewed copies**. The app checks the selected files again before removing them. This removes only the verified old reading PDFs. It keeps your main originals, tablet source files, saved notes and histories. Links in exported notebooks, personal documents or old

notebook backups may still point to the removed file; Notable cannot find every such document. Keep any old copy whose external links you still need.

Older image-bearing annotation history also remains saved even though new highlights and typed notes use text instead of screenshots. Changing that preview policy does not immediately shrink an existing database.

New tablet source storage separates shared baselines and annotation layers rather than repeating the baseline inside every raw archive. Older `.rmdoc` archives remain readable and untouched. Offline reconstruction and explicit portable `.rmdoc` export are supported by the source-storage code; these are not additional everyday buttons in the main interface.

Back up the right things

Close Notable, then back up:

1. Your actual paper folders, personal Word documents, and any adjacent **Notebook backups** folders.
2. The **complete active data directory**, including `library.sqlite3`, private `remarkable/` material, and retained `reMarkable Review/` contents.

Copying only the database does not include all retained tablet source files. Copying only generated notebooks does not include saved annotation history. Windows-protected pairing and Gemini credentials may need to be entered again under a different Windows account.

Troubleshooting

The wrong folders or connection appeared

Check **Settings** → **Library & diagnostics**. Source and older installed versions can use separate data directories. Use the source launch commands above and check any explicit `PDF_NOTES_DATA_DIR`. Diagnostics does not merge two libraries. Do not point a temporary test run at your normal saved library.

A watched folder is unavailable

Reconnect an offline drive first. If you already moved the folder, use **Locate moved folder…** on its existing Library entry. Saved notes remain readable while a source is unavailable. Removing the watched-folder entry is a different, explicit action that removes its saved project/history.

An Inbox document stays Waiting

Let the download complete, then refresh again after it stops changing. The file must be supported and directly inside the incoming folder. Files such as `.crdownload`, Office lock files, and unsupported documents are ignored. If the file changed during identification, review its current version again.

A PDF failed to read or its notes look wrong

Read the full error in **View sync details**. Restore a missing source or close an application that is holding it, then use **Library** → **Sync PDFs**. A failed scan does not replace the last successful saved notes.

Inspect **Open PDF** to see the combined annotations. Flattened marks are ordinary page content and cannot reliably be separated from the printed page; different flattened versions need review. A highlight without

extractable text keeps a source link and a review warning. For split/merged handwriting, adjust Folder settings and sync, then check a small sample before applying the approach broadly.

The generated notebook did not update

Close it in Word and check Library's log. Locked or failed exports remain pending. **Rebuild notebook…** uses saved notes and current formatting; **Sync PDFs** is needed when extraction data should change. Check **Notebook backups** if you had edited the generated file directly.

The tablet paper is missing or has Needs mapping

Confirm the Connections master switch, pairing, exact cloud source, available PC root, and selected folder mapping. Make sure the tablet has uploaded its changes over Wi-Fi. Refreshing folders alone does not download PDF annotations. Use **Sync PDFs**, then read the item's complete review explanation.

Missing or conflicting destinations do not authorize an unrelated location. Resolve the folder mapping, then retry. A local edit or unsupported scene can require manual review even when the route is correct.

A PDF update can leave a file beside the managed PDF named like `paper.pdf.<identifier>.preserved`. It contains the previous complete PDF. This can happen after an interruption, or after the new PDF was saved successfully but the previous copy could not be cleaned up. A recovery notice therefore does not always mean the new PDF failed to save.

Library's summary shows a count of **previous PDF copies retained for recovery**. Choose the footer's **View sync details** to open the log and read their complete saved paths. That clue stays available on later launches while the retained paths remain recorded. Open the containing folder, check the current PDF and retained copy, and compare them before deciding how to restore or organize them. The app does not blindly overwrite a retained previous copy or choose one for you.

An upload is held for review

Open **Transfer queue…** and inspect the selected job. Restore a missing source or resolve **Needs mapping** first. If the PDF or destination changed, confirm the current contents/location through **Retry selected…**. Use **Cancel selected transfer** when you no longer want that queued intent; cancellation is not remote deletion.

Save preferences failed

The dialog stays open with the error, and the previous saved settings/key remain. Correct the draft or cancel it. A key marked for removal can still be kept using Undo removal. If the message instead says preferences were saved but automatic checks could not restart, the save succeeded; use manual Inbox refresh and investigate that separate background error.

Open PDF opens at the wrong page

The page shown by Notable is the physical file position, which can differ from printed journal numbering. Choose a recognized viewer in Preferences. Some Windows-default or custom viewers ignore page parameters; navigate to the displayed physical page manually.

Reference and development

Data locations and migration

- Source default: `.local-data/` beside the source entry point.
- Older packaged default: `%LOCALAPPDATA%/PDF Note Organizer/`.
- Explicit override: `PDF_NOTES_DATA_DIR`.
- The project's `.local-data` skips legacy import by default. `PDF_NOTES_SKIP_LEGACY_IMPORT=1` disables it elsewhere; an explicit `0` permits it.
- Installed/custom libraries can import watched folder paths from nearby `notes_watcher.db` files on first migration. Old annotation hashes are not trusted; PDFs are re-extracted into the current library. The old databases and notebooks are left untouched.
- Local processing defaults in Settings apply to folders added later. Existing folders keep their own Folder settings.

Closing stops watchers and cancels extraction at supported page/annotation boundaries, retaining completed saved work. Automatic local/cloud tracking runs only while the app is open and catches up during later checks. There is no separate Windows service, tray mode, or automatic startup feature yet.

reMarkable compatibility

The cloud protocol is unofficial and follows community-documented v3/v4 endpoints from the reMarkable MCP client. Annotation parsing uses rmscene. Rendering uses calibrated device coordinates and simplified brush widths rather than the tablet's native renderer.

Supported v6 scenes become highlight, ink, and text annotations in a separate reading PDF. Snap-selected quotations come from tablet scene text; freehand highlighter marks remain drawings. Legacy indexed colors use their palette rather than black placeholder values, and highlight appearances are translucent. Selected quotations and actual typed comments remain distinct.

Renderer revisions can refresh managed PDFs even when their cloud hash is unchanged. Ordinary supported margin writing can extend the converted page canvas. Rotated/cropped pages needing unsupported margins, unknown blocks/coordinate grids, legacy highlight JSON, and unsupported text-anchored strokes stay in review with retained source data. Firmware and every pen workflow still require broader real-device validation; synthetic tests are not a guarantee of live compatibility.

Viewer and interface reference

Browsers receive encoded file URLs with `#page=`. Acrobat/Reader receive `/A page=`, and SumatraPDF receives `-page` with instance reuse. The adapters follow Adobe's PDF parameter documentation and SumatraPDF's command-line options.

The interface uses charcoal panels and blue accents. Blue usually marks the main action or selection. Muted controls are unavailable until their requirements are met; hover help explains many disabled actions. An ellipsis generally means a further choice or confirmation is needed.

Action buttons and menus use locally bundled Lucide icons. Icon-only utilities have hover help; workflow buttons combine icons and text. Icons scale with Tk display scaling and include disabled variants. Original SVGs, PNG

renders, the pinned upstream revision, and license notices are under `note_organizer/assets/icons/`; no network request is needed to display them. The existing PyInstaller specification includes those assets, but no new executable is part of this source update.

Tests and implementation

Run the suite from the project folder:

```
.\.venv\Scripts\python.exe -m unittest discover -s tests -v
```

The suite uses synthetic documents and temporary libraries, with cloud clients mocked. It covers PDF extraction/notebooks, document naming and Office exclusions, incomplete downloads, filing collisions/recovery, key removal and atomic preferences, paper links and independent history, source reconstruction, cloud transfer retries and changed destinations, folder scope, moved-folder recovery, and interface behavior.

For disposable visual examples:

```
.\.venv\Scripts\python.exe -m tests.qa_combined
.\.venv\Scripts\python.exe -m tests.qa_app
```

The combined preview uses `tmp/qa/combined`; the PDF preview example remains available. A small real pilot should include a clean PDF, a viewer-annotated PDF, and a tablet-annotated PDF before replacing an established workflow. COMBINED_APP_PLAN.md records scope and validation work. AUDIT.md, TOOLTIP_AUDIT.md, and ICON_AUDIT.md retain more technical review notes.

Implementation is split among extraction, SQLite database storage, Word export, a background service that coordinates changes one at a time, and the Tk interface. Desktop extraction, tablet conversion, and full-page rendering share a PDF worker in a separate Python process. The reader loads small saved-library views and performs searches separately from the window's controls. Word exports use a temporary file followed by replacement. Logs record processing times and unusually delayed interface updates for diagnosis.

Public source should be kept separate from private libraries, documents, logs, credentials, and built executables. Do not share `.local-data`, custom private data directories, or key files as part of the source project.

Features still under consideration

Manual crop and stroke merge/split controls, per-page settings, topic tags and custom color categories, richer personal synthesis editing, citation-manager integration, source-linked summaries, additional exports, and tray/startup operation remain future work. Current grouping and PDF reading order still need checking against the documents and annotation styles you use.